

Media capture is a form of systemic corruption in which mass media is controlled by governments, corporations, or powerful individuals to serve their own interests instead of the public interest, undermining media independence and media pluralism. The concept describes how vested interests can dominate or co-opt nominally independent media institutions through ownership, regulation, or financing, whilst maintaining the illusion of press freedom. The most widely held definition of the term was published by Alina Mungiu-Pippidi in 2008: "either directly by governments or by vested interests networked with politics".

According to Joseph Stiglitz: "Preventing capture, and ensuring that the media can perform their societal function, requires an understanding of the myriad and sometimes subtle ways the media can be compromised by the very actors they are supposed to monitor."

Description

Media capture occurs when media outlets fail to achieve autonomy from external power, operating instead as instruments of state or private agendas. It is distinguished from censorship by its indirect mechanisms—such as ownership concentration, clientelism, and state advertising—used to manipulate editorial independence. The phenomenon undermines the media's role as a watchdog, reducing its capacity to hold power to account.

According to Marius Dragomir, writing for UNESCO, media capture involves the takeover of four key levers of influence: media regulation, state-owned outlets, government financing, and private ownership. Governments can exert control through partisan appointments to regulatory bodies and manipulation of licensing or funding systems. In parallel, wealthy elites and corporations may use ownership or advertising leverage to align editorial policy with their political or economic interests.

Media capture reduces government accountability by limiting public access to independent information. Captured outlets tend to serve the interests of those in power, enabling corruption and rent extraction. It can also exacerbate income inequality by allowing elites to

shape narratives that justify policies benefiting them.

Historical development

The idea of media capture builds on theories of elite influence and the propaganda model proposed by Edward S. Herman and Noam Chomsky. Historically, captured media systems have appeared in both authoritarian and democratic contexts, including Russia, Hungary, Turkey, and Mexico. In these cases, political-business alliances have consolidated control over major news outlets, marginalizing critical journalism.

In recent years, scholars have written that media capture has taken place in the United States.

Prevention and responses

Scholars and NGOs propose transparency in ownership, independent regulation, and new models for public-interest journalism as remedies. Organizations such as Reporters Without Borders, Freedom House, Article 19, and the Center for International Media Assistance campaign to expose and counteract media capture through advocacy and monitoring initiatives. These efforts emphasize that media capture, like regulatory capture, represents a systemic threat to democracy.

See also

Regulatory capture

Political corruption

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